Understanding Unix

NUnix · L3 MIAGE · CM1 · 90 minutes

ISTIC · University of Rennes 2026–2027

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Linux is closer than you think

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You can use it all day without opening a terminal.

Yes, even the coffee machine

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Android phones
The **Linux kernel** manages processes, memory and hardware.
Google · platform architecture

Freebox Server Pop
A home internet box. Free publishes its **Linux source code**.
Free · firmware 4.9.10

MARO Model One
A coffee machine with **embedded Linux**, remote support and updates.
Toradex · May 2026

Linux can run behind a touchscreen or a web interface.

Unix and Linux usage

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Mobile web use
69.17%
of observed mobile page views come from **Android**, built on Linux.
Statcounter · Sept 2026

Websites
92.1%
use the **Unix family**, including Linux, among sites whose OS W3Techs identifies.
W3Techs · 1 Oct 2026

Supercomputers
500/500
systems in the **June 2026 TOP500 list** use the Linux family.
TOP500 · June 2026

Course structure

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Three lectures of 90 minutes.

Lecture	Topics	Application
CM1 · Unix	Files, paths and permissions	Find files and check access
CM2 · Commands	Processes, search, pipes and redirections	Count errors in a log
CM3 · Bash	Variables, conditions, loops and functions	Write scripts with arguments and loops

The exercises practise commands first, then scripts.

One line, a useful result

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Which errors occur most often in **1,000 log entries**?

```
sort < errors.log | uniq -c | sort -nr | tee output.txt |
  a2ps -1 -o - | ps2pdf - rapport.pdf
```

Save the counts in `output.txt` and the report in `rapport.pdf`.

errors.log · first three lines

```
Database timeout
Login rejected
Connection refused
```

output.txt · first three counts

```
    320 Database timeout
    210 Login rejected
    140 Connection refused
```

`a2ps`: text → PostScript
`ps2pdf`: PostScript → PDF

By the end of this course, you will understand this command.

Why use a script?

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A **script** stores shell commands in a text file.

Save the report command in a file.
Run that file when you need the report again.

With Bash, we can also:

- Pass a filename as an **argument**.
- Store values in **variables**.
- Choose and repeat commands with **conditions and loops**.

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Which tool fits the task?

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Task	A useful starting point
Explore sales figures, filter and make a chart	Excel or another graphical analysis tool
Inspect a server's logs, processes and permissions	Remote shell and system commands
Apply the same sequence of commands to several files	A shell script with arguments and a loop
Query related business tables	SQL and a database
Explain the result to the team	A spreadsheet, dashboard or report

Excel also offers Power Query and Office Scripts for repeatable work.

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1. Linux and the shell

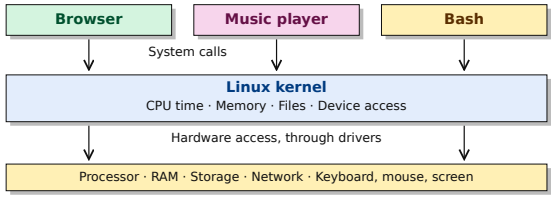
What happens between typing a command and the machine doing the work?

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Programs, kernel and hardware

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Music, downloads and commands run at the same time.



The kernel **shares resources and controls access**.

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Linux

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- **1991:** Linus Torvalds announces his kernel project.
- Linux is a **Unix-like kernel**, distributed as free and open source software.
- A distribution combines the kernel with tools, libraries and applications.

Our working environment: a Linux system with the **Bash shell** and command-line tools.

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Unix, GNU and Linux

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Name	Meaning
Unix	The operating-system family that inspired Linux
GNU	The project behind Bash and many command-line tools
Linux	The kernel: manages processes, memory and hardware

GNU = GNU's Not Unix.
The name contains itself: a recursive acronym.

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Touch, click or type

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You already use interfaces to start programs.

Your action	Interface	Example
Touch a phone screen	Graphical interface	Open an app from its launcher
Click with a mouse	Graphical interface	Open a folder in a file manager
Type a command	Text interface	Ask Bash to list a directory

A smartphone can be a **terminal**: an endpoint for using a service.
Its touchscreen, like a mouse or keyboard, provides **input**.

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Our terminal for this course?

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DEC VT100 · IF-3-SYS, G. Salagnac, INSA Lyon

A **physical terminal** sends keystrokes to a computer and displays its replies.
The programs run on the connected computer.

Good news: yours fits in a window.

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Terminal, shell and command

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Name	Role
Terminal emulator	A window for keyboard input and text output
Bash, the shell	Interprets the line and runs commands
`ls`, a command	Lists directory entries

Type `ls` → Bash runs `ls` → the terminal displays its output.

TTY = *teletypewriter*: early terminals printed on paper.
Unix keeps the name, even for emulated terminals.

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A command and its arguments

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```
ls -l /home/alice
```

Part	Role
`ls`	**Command**: list directory entries
`-l`	**Option**: change how `ls` lists them
`/home/alice`	**Operand**: the directory to list

Both `-l` and `/home/alice` are **arguments** passed to `ls`.

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Short and long options

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Form	Example	Meaning for GNU `ls`
Short: **one dash**	`ls -a`	Include hidden entries
Long: **two dashes**	`ls --all`	Same as `-a`
Combined	`ls -la`	`-l` and `-a` together

Some options take a value: `head -n 5 notes.txt` prints five lines.

A **bare `--` ends options**.
`ls -- -notes.txt` treats `-notes.txt` as a filename.

Each command defines its options. Check `--help` or `man`.

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Getting help

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```
man ls
info coreutils
apropos directory
help cd
```

- **Tab** completes a name or displays possible completions.
- **Up** recalls a previous command. `history` lists history.
- `clear` clears the display. In `man`, **q** quits.

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2. Files and directories

Where is my file, and what can I do with it?

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One directory tree

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A **directory** is a folder: it contains names of files and other directories.

```
/
├── home/
│   └── alice/
│       └── notes.txt
└── etc/
```

The common root is `/`. The path `/home/alice/notes.txt` follows the tree.
Alice's **home directory** is `/home/alice`; the university may use a different path.

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Where Linux stores files

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Need	Typical location
Alice's personal files	`/home/alice`
System configuration	`/etc`
Installed add-on applications	`/opt`
Changing application data	`/var/lib`
Log files	`/var/log`

Configuration: /etc · Logs: /var/log

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Users, administrators and software

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Directory	Typical role
`/home`, `/root`	User homes; the root account's home
`/usr`	Most distribution-provided tools and libraries
`/usr/local`	Software installed locally by the administrator
`/opt`	Add-on software packages

`/` is the filesystem root.
`root` is also the administrator account's name.

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Temporary files and system information

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Directory	Purpose / lifetime
`/var`	Changing data, often persistent
`/tmp`	Temporary files; cleanup policy varies
`/run`	Runtime state, cleared at boot
`/dev`	Device interfaces
`/proc`, `/sys`	Views of processes, kernel and devices

A path can expose live system information.
It need not refer to ordinary data stored on disk.

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Several filesystems, one tree

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```
/
├── home/       user files
├── mnt/        a temporary mount point
└── media/      removable media mount points
```

Mounting makes another filesystem visible at a directory.
The device node might be `/dev/sdb1`; its files appear at the mount point.

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The current directory

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Notation	Meaning
`.`	Current working directory
`..`	Parent directory
`/`	Root directory
`~`	Your home directory, expanded by the shell
`$HOME`	Variable containing your home path
`$PWD`	Variable containing the current directory path

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Absolute and relative paths

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Current directory: `/home/alice`

Path	Interpretation
`/home/alice/notes.txt`	Absolute: start at `/`
`notes.txt`	Relative: start in the current directory
`./notes.txt`	The same relative path
`../bob/notes.txt`	Go to the parent, then into `bob`

A path tells us **where to look**. Permissions determine whether access is allowed.

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Moving around

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```
pwd
cd /home/alice
cd ..
cd
```

- `pwd` prints the current working directory.
- `cd path` changes the current directory.
- `cd` or `cd ~` returns to your home.

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Listing directory entries

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```
ls
ls -l
ls -a
ls -la /home/alice
```

- `-l` adds details, including ownership and permissions.
- `-a` includes names beginning with `.`, such as `.bashrc`.
- `ls directory` lists that directory's contents.

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Creating and removing directories

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```
mkdir practice
rmdir practice
```

`rmdir` removes an **empty** directory.

`rm -r practice` also removes the directory's contents.
Shell deletion does **not** send files to a recycle bin.

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Creating, copying and moving files

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```
touch notes.txt
cp notes.txt notes-copy.txt
mv notes-copy.txt archive.txt
rm archive.txt
```

`touch` creates a missing file, or updates timestamps of an existing file.

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Reading text files

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Command	Result
`cat notes.txt`	Print the whole file
`less notes.txt`	Browse interactively, **q** to quit
`more notes.txt`	Browse a page at a time
`head -n 5 notes.txt`	Print the first five lines
`tail -n 5 notes.txt`	Print the last five lines
`diff old.txt new.txt`	Show differences between two files

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Why is less called less?

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Mark Nudelman was investigating errors in large logs.
He wanted to read the lines **before** an error.

His version of `more` could not move backward.
The new pager's name joked about a **backward more**.

```
less app.log
```

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Concatenating files

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```
cat first.txt second.txt
cat
```

- With filenames, `cat` prints their contents **in argument order**.
- Without filenames, `cat` reads **standard input**.
- At an empty terminal input line, **Ctrl+D** indicates end of input.

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Filename patterns

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Pattern	Matches
`?`	Exactly one character
`*`	Zero or more characters
`[abc]`	One character from the set

```
ls /etc/rc*
ls /etc/rc????
ls [abc]oo.c
```

The **shell** expands these patterns before running `ls`.

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Spaces separate arguments

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Our file is named **`meeting notes.txt`**, including the space.

Without quotes

```
cat meeting notes.txt
```

Two filename arguments:
`meeting` and `notes.txt`.
`cat` tries to open two files.

With quotes

```
cat "meeting notes.txt"
```

One filename argument:
`meeting notes.txt`.
`cat` opens the intended file.

The shell removes the quotes. They are **instructions for the shell**.

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Three ways to protect a space

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These commands all pass **the same filename** to `cat`:

```
cat 'meeting notes.txt'
cat "meeting notes.txt"
cat meeting\ notes.txt
```

- **Single quotes** preserve everything inside them literally.
- **Double quotes** preserve spaces, but still allow `$HOME` to expand.
- An unquoted **backslash** protects the next character, such as a space or `*`.

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What expands inside quotes?

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Suppose `$HOME` contains `/home/alice`.

Command	Output
`echo '$HOME'`	`$HOME`
`echo "$HOME"`	`/home/alice`
`echo "$HOME/*.txt"`	`/home/alice/*.txt`
`echo "It's OK"`	`It's OK`
`echo 'Say "hi"'`	`Say "hi"`

Double quotes expand the variable, but keep spaces and * literal.
The other kind of quote can appear as ordinary text inside quotes.

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Filename patterns: expanded or literal?

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The directory contains only **`a.txt`** and **`meeting notes.txt`**.

Expand the pattern

```
echo *.txt
```

```
a.txt meeting notes.txt
```

The shell finds matching filenames.

Keep the pattern literal

```
echo '*.txt'
```

```
*.txt
```

`echo "*.txt"` and `echo \*.txt` also print `*.txt`.

`echo` separates its arguments with spaces. Its output hides their boundaries.

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Seeing each argument with printf

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`printf '<%s>\n'` prints each following argument between < and >, on its own line.

```
printf '<%s>\n' *.txt
```

```
<a.txt>
<meeting notes.txt>
```

Two arguments. The space inside the matched filename stays intact.

```
printf '<%s>\n' '*.txt'
```

```
<*.txt>
```

One argument. The quoted pattern stays literal.

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Checkpoint: files and paths

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1. What does `cd ..` do?
2. Which `ls` option includes hidden entries?
3. What does `cat a.txt b.txt` print first?
4. Does `echo '*.txt'` expand the pattern?

1. Move to the parent directory.
2. `-a`
3. The contents of `a.txt`.
4. No. Single quotes preserve the literal *.

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3. Who may access this file?

Why can I read this file, but cannot change or delete it?

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Users, groups and ownership

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```
whoami
id
ls -ld .
ls -l
```

- `id` shows your user identity and groups.
- `ls -l` shows the file's owner, group and permission bits.
- `ls -ld` inspects a directory itself.

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Permission classes

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```
-rwxr-xr--
  u  g  o
```

Class	Applies to
u	The file's owner
g	Members of the file's group
o	Other users
a	All three classes when using `chmod`

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What r, w and x allow

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Bit	Regular file	Directory
r	Read contents	List entry names
w	Modify contents	Add or remove entries*
x	Execute	Search / traverse

*Changing directory entries also requires search permission. Other restrictions, such as the sticky bit, may apply.

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Changing permission bits

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```
chmod u+x script.sh
chmod go-w notes.txt
chmod u=rw,g=r,o= notes.txt
```

- `+` adds the selected permission bits.
- `-` removes them.
- `=` sets the selected class to the listed permissions.

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Numeric permissions

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Each class adds its bit values: **r = 4**, **w = 2**, **x = 1**.

Owner	Group	Others
`rwx` = **7**	`rw-` = **6**	`r--` = **4**

```
chmod 764 notes.txt
```

The three digits describe **owner, group, others**, in that order.

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Checkpoint: permissions

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1. Decode `640` for a regular file.
2. Add execute permission for the owner of `run.sh`.
3. Which directory bit allows traversal?

1. Owner: `rw-`
   Group: `r--`
   Others: `---`
2. `chmod u+x run.sh`
3. `x`

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“I can see the name, but cannot read it”

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```
# Illustrative server metadata
 drwxr----- alice students  shared/
 -rw-r----- alice students  shared/notes.txt
```

Bob belongs to `students`. He can list the names, but cannot open `notes.txt`. Why?

The directory’s group bits lack **x**: traversal.
If team access is intended, the owner can add `g+x`.

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CM1 summary: files and permissions

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1. Locate configuration, software, data and logs.
2. List and read files; quote names containing spaces.
3. Check owner, group and other permissions.

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Optional reference

Examples to revisit during TD or personal practice

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Operating system, shell and GUI

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Layer	What it gives us
Operating system	Processes, storage and access control
Graphical interface	Windows, menus and direct visual interaction
Shell	Commands we can combine and save in scripts
Application	A task-specific tool, such as Excel or a database

Your laptop can run Windows while the company's application runs on Linux. You need to work with both.

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Summarise a log before opening it in Excel

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Quantity	Meaning
2,000,000 log lines	Example input size
1,048,576 rows	The maximum in one Excel worksheet
One row per error code	The summary the team wants to discuss

Process the raw log where it lives, save the counts, then use Excel to analyse or present the summary.

Microsoft: worksheet limits. Power Query and the Data Model offer other ways to handle larger datasets.

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Path components and word counts

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```
dirname /home/alice/notes.txt
basename /home/alice/notes.txt
wc -w notes.txt
```

- `dirname` prints `/home/alice`.
- `basename` prints `notes.txt`.
- `wc -w` counts **words**. `wc -l` counts newline characters.

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Hard links and symbolic links

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Hard link

```
ln notes.txt other.txt
```

- Another name for the **same file**.
- Removing one name leaves the other usable.
- Same filesystem, normally no directory links.

Symbolic link

```
ln -s notes.txt shortcut
```

- Stores a **path** to a target.
- May cross filesystems or target a directory.
- Can become dangling if the target path disappears.

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Builtins and external commands

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Builtin

Implemented inside the shell.

```
cd ..
```

Can change the current shell's state.

External program

Loaded from an executable file.

```
ls -l
```

The shell searches directories in PATH.

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Recognising a command

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```
type cd
type ls
type -a echo
help cd
```

`type` reports how Bash resolves a name.
`help` documents its builtins.

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